

Select the Clone Stamp tool, keep [Alt] pressed, and then left-click on an area you want to sample. Now, let go of [Alt] and then just begin painting. This tool is a godsend for those of us who have wrinkles or no hair. You can use the Clone Stamp to hide your wrinkles or bald spots—digitally, though. This still beats all the fitness diets, wrinkle creams and advice from elders!

Let's look at the image of the old lady. As you can see, she's got a lot of wrinkles, which she may or may not be happy about, but we're going to "soften" them anyway—and try and make her look a few years younger, using just the Clone Stamp tool. You can create a new layer by right-clicking on the background layer and selecting Duplicate Layer. Now work on the new layer you've created. It takes a little patience and deft mouse work, but you can achieve decent results. You might have to use the History palette quite often, especially when you accidentally sample the wrong area with the Clone Stamp, and end up with a big unsightly pink or black patch in the middle of the face.

The trick is to sample the smoother skin that's close to the wrinkles, and then paint it over the wrinkles. The reason why you choose skin close to the wrinkles is because you need the same, or at least similar, lighting and skin tone to make it look credible.

Now, we're using the layer on top of the actual background because the Clone Stamp tool flattens the image, and is not particularly good when it comes to skin—it's better used on areas of solid colours. So once you're done stamping out the wrinkles, you might feel that the image looks too plastic and flat, and that all the details of the face have been wiped clean. This is where the original image in the background layer comes in. Play with the Opacity and Fill values of the top layer to let some of the details of the background layer come through. This will give you the missing details, and also show lighter wrinkles instead of the "no wrinkle look" (which looks plastic) on the face.